

AK.4 Where to File Directory

Alaska's hardest question is whether anyone regulates your parcel at all. No published list answers it, so this document gives you the five questions that do — and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Alaska has no statewide residential building code and, over most of its land area, no local building department either — so what binds your house is a short stack of *state* rules that apply whether or not anyone inspects, plus whatever your borough, your city, your lender and your utility require on top. Confirm every item with the office that will actually decide it before you rely on it.

THERE IS NO LIST — AND THAT IS THE FINDING

In most states, an owner-builder's first task is to find the right counter. In Alaska it is to find out whether a counter exists. Several states publish a jurisdiction list that answers this parcel by parcel. **Alaska publishes nothing of the kind**, for a reason that is structural rather than administrative: the state never took the power to regulate houses in the first place, so it has nothing to delegate and no register of who has taken it up.

The Department of Public Safety's authority to set building standards runs to "*buildings used for residential purposes containing **four or more dwelling units***," and the code it adopts excludes "*Detached one-, two-, and three-family dwellings*" in terms. Below that line, whether your house is reviewed is entirely a question of what your borough or city has chosen to do — and boroughs and cities are separate governments with separate answers on the same map.

AS 18.70.080(a)(2); 13 AAC 50.020, adopting the International Building Code 2021 edition, Section 101.2 Exception 1. Read at akleg.gov, August 2026.

The single most expensive mistake in Alaska owner-building

The borough and the city are different governments, and on this question they usually give different answers. In the Fairbanks North Star Borough, the Matanuska-Susitna Borough, the Kenai Peninsula Borough, the Ketchikan Gateway Borough and the Kodiak Island Borough, the **borough has no building code** and **cities inside it do**. A parcel two miles apart can face a full plan review or none at all.

The Fairbanks North Star Borough states the pattern more cleanly than any summary could: *"Building permits are only required within the City of Fairbanks and City of North Pole. Since the FNSB has not adopted a building code, building permits are not required in the Borough at-large outside of these two cities."* Establish which side of a city line your parcel sits on **from the borough parcel viewer, not from your mailing address** — a rural address routinely carries a nearby city's name while the lot sits outside it.

THE FIVE QUESTIONS THAT SETTLE YOUR PARCEL

Ask them in this order. Each one changes which office you ask next, and the answers together determine everything in AK.2 and AK.3.

Work these in order, and write the answers into the directory below

	Question	Why it decides what happens next
1	Which borough is the parcel in — or is it in the unorganized borough?	Organized boroughs cover a minority of Alaska's land area. If you are in the unorganized borough there is no borough government at all, and the questions below collapse to the state and federal ones.
2	Is the parcel inside a city's limits?	This is the question people get wrong, because a rural mailing address often carries a nearby city's name while the parcel sits outside it. A city can enforce a full building code inside a borough that enforces none. Confirm from the parcel viewer, not the mailing address.
3	Does that borough or city issue a building permit for a single-family dwelling — and under which code edition?	Ask both governments separately, and ask for the <i>edition</i> in writing. Local adoptions differ from each other and from the state minimums, and buying the wrong code book is an expensive way to find out.
4	Is your community at or above 2,500 population?	At or above it, the state plumbing code applies to your new construction and the Department of Labor inspects — including on parcels with no building department whatsoever. Below it, the community is exempt from the chapter outright.
5	Who regulates onsite wastewater here — DEC, or a delegated local program?	On a parcel with no building department this is normally the only mandatory approval of the entire build, and it has the longest lead time. Establish the office before you pay anyone for a soils test.

AS 18.60.735 — "An organized municipality or unorganized village having less than 2,500 population is exempt from the provisions of AS 18.60.705 — 18.60.740"; 18 AAC 72 for onsite wastewater. Municipalities may set standards "no less stringent" than the state's for plumbing (AS 18.60.735) and electrical work (AS 18.60.590(b)) — so a local answer can be stricter than the state one, never weaker.

THE MAP AS IT STOOD IN AUGUST 2026

Below is what each of these governments was doing when this edition was compiled, read from each one's own code or published page. **It is a starting point for question 3, not a substitute for it.** An assembly can adopt or repeal a code in one session, and two of the entries below changed within the last year — so use this to know what to expect, and the five questions to know what is true.

Issues residential building permits — and the edition it enforces

Jurisdiction	Residential code	Citation and what to watch
Anchorage	2024 IRC	AMC 23.05.010; local amendments AMC ch. 23.85. Adopted April 2026 — not the 2018 edition still quoted online. NEC 2023.
Juneau	2024 IRC	CBJ 19.04.R010.1, effective October 2025. NEC 2023. Note CBJ 19.04.R010.2 pulls in the fire code's apparatus access provisions — a real gate on a rural lot.
Kenai	2021 IRC	KMC 4.32.010, amendments KMC 4.32.015 — heavy: 70 psf ground snow, 42 in. frost depth, –18 °F winter design, sprinklers deleted.
Seward	2021 IRC	SCC 12.05.021. SCC 12.01.025 makes a water/sewer receipt a prerequisite to any building, electrical or plumbing permit.
Sitka	2021 IRC	Plus 2021 UPC and 2020 NEC. Published design criteria: 150 mph wind, 50 psf ground snow, 18 in. minimum frost depth.
Fairbanks (city)	2018 IRC	FGC 10-401. NEC 2020. The borough around it issues nothing — see below.
North Pole	2018 IRC	NPMC Title 15.
Palmer	2015 IRC	PMC 15.12.010, amendments PMC 15.16. PMC 15.12.020 lets the building official modify provisions on written application " <i>when there are practical difficulties.</i> "
Ketchikan (city)	2012 IRC	KMC Title 19. The city's own handout limits the IRC to single-family and duplex; triplex and larger go to the IBC.
Kodiak (city)	2012 IRC	KCC 14.04.010. Its amendments delete the IRC plumbing and electrical chapters in favor of the UPC and NEC.
Soldotna	2012 IRC	SMC 15.07.010. Adopts other codes expressly " <i>with all revisions in 13 AAC 50.020</i> " — state amendments layered on a local edition.
Valdez	2009 IRC	VMC 15.06.010. Permit expiry extended to 360 days. Ask about VMC 15.06.070's amendment naming <i>each contractor</i> as the permit applicant — it matters to an owner-builder.
Nome	2009 IRC	Nome Code ch. 5.10. "A permit is required for all new construction."

Fifteen years of code editions are in force in Alaska simultaneously

Look down that middle column: **2009 in Valdez and Nome, 2012 in Ketchikan, Kodiak and Soldotna, 2015 in Palmer, 2018 in Fairbanks and North Pole, 2021 in Kenai, Seward and Sitka, 2024 in Anchorage and Juneau.** There is no state cycle pulling them together, so a builder moving between two Alaska towns is working to codes fifteen years apart.

Anchorage and Juneau both moved to the 2024 codes very recently — Anchorage in April 2026, Juneau in October 2025. That is precisely why the "Anchorage uses the 2018 IRC" claim is still circulating in guides and forums. **Buy the code book after you confirm the edition, not before.**

Issues no residential building permit — and what it requires instead

Jurisdiction	What applies instead
Fairbanks North Star Borough	No building code, no building permit outside the two cities — the borough says so in terms. Does run a floodplain permit and service-area driveway and right-of-way permits.
Matanuska-Susitna Borough	No building permit exists. Does require a driveway permit on a borough road, a floodplain development permit in a mapped hazard area (MSB 17.29), an address request, and encroachment and utility permits. See the trap below.
Kenai Peninsula Borough	No building code — its Title 18 "Buildings and Construction" contains only local-hire and public-works-contract chapters. Does set building setbacks (KPB 20.30) and issues driveway, encroachment and near-water permits.
Ketchikan Gateway Borough	No building permit; issues a zoning permit "for most new construction," plus floodplain and driveway permits. City of Ketchikan residents need both.
Kodiak Island Borough	No borough building permit; issues zoning compliance permits and refers building permits to the City of Kodiak. Whether the city inspects outside city limits — confirm locally .
City of Wasilla	No building code. But a land use administrative permit is required "before the construction, alteration, addition, or modification of a building" (WMC 16.90.010.B), with an as-built survey after any structure over 250 sq ft. Owner-friendly detail: you may draw your own site plan.
City of Homer	States it plainly: "The City of Homer does not have a building inspection program and does not issue building permits." Issues a zoning permit, driveway permit and water/sewer permit instead.
North Slope Borough	No building code found; the residential gate is a District Residential Permit covering "digging for foundation and building homes." Confirm locally.

Issues no residential building permit — and what it requires instead

Jurisdiction	What applies instead
Unorganized borough	No local government at all, so no building permit, no zoning and no local plan review. Only the state and federal gates in this kit apply.

Two Mat-Su traps, one of them a permit you do not need

The "Borough Land Use Permit" is not a zoning permit for your house. It authorizes commercial or private use of unimproved *borough-owned* land, carries liability insurance and a security deposit, and is administered by the Land Management Division. Building on your own lot, you do not need one — and people apply for it anyway because the name sounds like the thing they are looking for.

The driveway permit depends on whose road it is. The borough permits a tie-in to a *borough* road; a state-maintained road is Alaska DOT&PF; a private road needs neither but does need your easement. The borough's own guidance is to confirm jurisdiction before applying.

*Adopted editions and permit status read from each jurisdiction's own municipal code or published page, August 2026: Anchorage AMC 23.05.010 and ch. 23.85; Juneau CBJ 19.04.R010.1-.2; Kenai KMC 4.32.010, .015; Seward SCC 12.05.021, 12.01.025; Sitka published design criteria; Fairbanks FGC 10-401; North Pole NPMC Title 15; Palmer PMC 15.12.010, .020; Ketchikan KMC Title 19; Kodiak KCC 14.04.010; Soldotna SMC 15.07.010; Valdez VMC 15.06.010, .070; Nome Code ch. 5.10; Kenai Peninsula Borough Title 18 and 20.30; Mat-Su MSB 17.29; Wasilla WMC 16.90.010, .020. **The City of Bethel could not be verified either way** and is deliberately omitted rather than guessed at. Two jurisdictions' trade-code editions were also unverifiable — Seward's plumbing and electrical editions are adopted as "the city designated edition" with no year in the code, and Palmer's non-residential editions were not confirmed. Ask.*

THE DEFERRED-JURISDICTION LIST, AND WHAT IT IS NOT

The State Fire Marshal publishes a list of **deferred jurisdictions** — governments that have taken over fire and life safety plan review from the state under AS 18.70.080. You will find this list, and you will be tempted to read it as "the places with building departments." **It is not that list**, and the difference matters.

As it stood in August 2026 it named thirteen entries: **Anchorage Fire Department, Anchorage Building Safety, City of Palmer, Juneau, Fairbanks, Kenai, Ketchikan, Seward, Kodiak, Sitka, Soldotna, University of Alaska Fairbanks, and Central Mat-Su Fire Service Area.** Read it carefully: the entries are **cities**, not boroughs — "Fairbanks" is the city, not the borough around it; "Kodiak" is the city, not the island borough. One entry is a university and one is a fire service area.

Deferral moves fire plan review, not your building permit

The Fire Marshal's own page states the underlying rule and its exemption together: "Construction, repair, remodel, addition, or change of occupancy of any building or structure ... must be approved by the State Fire Marshal before any work begins," and then — **"Residential housing that is three-plex or smaller is exempt from this requirement."**

So deferral transfers an authority that **never reached your house in the first place**. A jurisdiction can be on that list and still issue you no building permit, and the Central Mat-Su Fire Service Area is exactly that case — it holds deferred fire plan review inside a borough that issues no building permits at all.

Alaska Department of Public Safety, Division of Fire and Life Safety, Plan Review — dps.alaska.gov → Divisions → Fire and Life Safety → Plan Review, read August 2026. Authority stated on that page: AS 18.70.080 and 13 AAC 50.027.

WHAT IS FIXED NO MATTER HOW THOSE QUESTIONS COME OUT

Three things do not depend on your borough at all. They are the reason "nobody regulates my parcel" is never quite true, and they are the part of Alaska that catches out people who have checked only with their borough.

Applies on every parcel in Alaska

What	Where it comes from	Authority
Smoke and CO alarms	Required in every dwelling unit in the state , by statute, enforced as a class B misdemeanor. Detail in AK.2.	AS 18.70.095
The 2020 NEC	The state minimum electrical code. Your single-family house is not inspected by the State — but the standard still applies and knowing violation is a misdemeanor. AK.1.	8 AAC 70.025(a)
Onsite wastewater	DEC regulates statewide except where it has delegated the program locally. No borough opts out of this. AK.2, Step 2.	18 AAC 72

THE OFFICES THAT APPLY WITH OR WITHOUT A BUILDING PERMIT

Where no building department assembles these for you, this is the list nobody hands you. Each is a different government, and several will not know the others exist.

Finding the right office for your parcel

What you need	Who has it, and how to get there
Onsite wastewater	Alaska DEC — dec.alaska.gov → Water → Wastewater → Onsite — or the delegated borough or municipal program. Ask which one covers your parcel <i>before</i> commissioning any soils work.

Finding the right office for your parcel

What you need	Who has it, and how to get there
Plumbing and gas permits, certificates of fitness, boilers	Alaska Department of Labor and Workforce Development, Labor Standards and Safety Division, Mechanical Inspection Section — labor.alaska.gov → Labor Standards and Safety → Mechanical Inspection. This is the state office an Alaska owner-builder is most likely to meet.
Contractor registration	Division of Corporations, Business and Professional Licensing — commerce.alaska.gov → Professional Licensing → Construction Contractors. Also where the AS 08.18.161(11) owner-builder notice is filed, and where you verify anyone you hire.
Zoning, land use, platting, 911 addressing	Your borough's planning department, and your city's if the parcel is inside one. These exist in Alaska boroughs with no building code at all — never assume no building permit means no permit.
Driveway / access	Alaska Department of Transportation and Public Facilities — dot.alaska.gov — for a tie-in to a state-maintained road; otherwise the borough, the city, or the road association that maintains it.
Floodplain	Your community's floodplain administrator, usually in the borough or city planning office. State coordination sits with the Division of Community and Regional Affairs at commerce.alaska.gov .
Wetlands	U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, Alaska District — a federal permit, entirely independent of anything the state or your borough says. Ask at the site-planning stage.
Water rights and well logs	Alaska Department of Natural Resources, Division of Mining, Land and Water — dnr.alaska.gov . Ordinary single-family domestic use normally needs no water right; confirm rather than assume.
Fire and life safety	State Fire Marshal, Division of Fire and Life Safety, Department of Public Safety — dps.alaska.gov . Plan review reaches four or more dwelling units, but the statewide smoke-alarm standard is theirs and it reaches you.
Energy standard and financing	Alaska Housing Finance Corporation — ahfc.us — for the state energy standard and its loan programs, plus whatever your own lender imposes. Where no government reviews your house, this is the layer that does.
Electric utility	Your cooperative or utility sets its own conditions for energizing a new service, and in unincorporated Alaska that is frequently the only technical review your wiring will get. Ask before you set the meter base.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each of these by phone rather than copying it from a search result, and write down the name of the person you spoke to. In a small Alaska office a name is worth more than a number, and the same person will still be there when you call back in April. Phone numbers are left blank deliberately — a wrong number printed in a kit is worse than no number.

THE FIVE ANSWERS

Borough (or Unorganized): _____ Inside a city? Which: _____

Building permit required? Y / N: _____ By whom: _____ Code edition: _____

Community population: _____ State plumbing? Y / N: _____ Confirmed: _____

Wastewater regulated by: _____ Confirmed: _____

BUILDING PERMIT — borough or city — or write NONE, and note who you asked

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

WASTEWATER — DEC or the delegated local program — start here

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PLUMBING & GAS — state Mechanical Inspection where the community is 2,500 or more

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ZONING / LAND USE — setbacks, use, waterfront setbacks — exists without a building code

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

911 ADDRESSING — borough or city — needed before utilities

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

DRIVEWAY / ACCESS — DOT&PF on a state road, otherwise borough, city or road association

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

FLOODPLAIN — community floodplain administrator, if in a mapped hazard area

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY — temporary construction power, and conditions for energizing

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

LENDER — construction standard, draw inspections, energy requirement

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing. Navigation routes are given rather than deep links, because Alaska agency URLs move and a domain plus a route survives a redesign.

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Labor and Workforce Development Mechanical Inspection Section	Plumbing and gas permits and inspections where the community is 2,500 or more; electrical inspection at three-plex and above; certificates of fitness; boilers and pressure vessels. The state office you are most likely to deal with.	labor.alaska.gov
Commerce, Community, and Economic Development Corporations, Business and Professional Licensing	Contractor registration and the residential contractor endorsement; the free license search you use before hiring anyone; the owner-builder notice under AS 08.18.161(11).	commerce.alaska.gov
Environmental Conservation Division of Water	Onsite wastewater under 18 AAC 72, and the list of local programs to which it has delegated review. Drinking water guidance for private wells.	dec.alaska.gov
Public Safety Fire and Life Safety / State Fire Marshal	Plan review for buildings of four or more dwelling units and non-residential occupancies; the statewide smoke-alarm installation standard that reaches every dwelling in Alaska.	dps.alaska.gov
Alaska Housing Finance Corporation	The state residential energy standard and the loan and rebate programs that carry it. Where no government reviews your house, an AHFC-backed loan is often what does.	ahfc.us

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Natural Resources Mining, Land and Water	Water rights and the well log database — useful before you drill, to see what neighboring wells found and at what depth.	dnr.alaska.gov
Transportation and Public Facilities	Driveway and approach permits where you tie into a state-maintained road.	dot.alaska.gov
Alaska Legislature	The statutes and the Administrative Code themselves, free and current — every AS and AAC citation in this kit was read here. Bills & Laws → Alaska Statutes, or → Alaska Administrative Code.	akleg.gov

Sources (verified August 2026). The Fire Marshal's residential authority and the four-dwelling-unit line: AS 18.70.080(a)(2), and 13 AAC 50.020 adopting the 2021 IBC with Section 101.2 Exception 1 excluding detached one-, two- and three-family dwellings. The 2,500 population line for the state plumbing chapter: AS 18.60.735. Local standards may be no less stringent than the state's: AS 18.60.735 (plumbing) and AS 18.60.590(b) (electrical). State electrical inspection scope: 8 AAC 70.010 with the definition of "public structure" at 8 AAC 70.090(4). Onsite wastewater: 18 AAC 72. Agency scope descriptions confirmed against each agency's own pages, read August 2026. Statutes and regulations at akleg.gov.